seriousness, ‘Rajdeep, television channels can fix ratings and I can fix a poll!’

Personally, I was troubled by the tamasha that exit polls had become. It felt as though the months of effort in reporting and analysing an election were being reduced to a single number. If you got your exit poll number right, then it was as if your entire election coverage was validated. If you got it wrong, then you were scoffed at, and all the good work done previously was consigned to oblivion. It was almost as if the soul of journalism was being mortgaged to the marketplace—every channel had to do a poll because that was what the viewer supposedly wanted.

I will never forget the trauma I went through during the 2012 UP elections. Our exit poll had predicted a comprehensive win for the SP and a rout for the Congress and the BJP. But in the first hour on results day, the BJP was actually leading, with most of the leads coming from postal ballots and early counting. That was enough for a senior BJP leader to come on air and demand an apology from Yogendra and me. ‘You should apologize to the people of India for having misled them. Your poll has been proven to be totally wrong,’ the BJP leader insisted. For the BJP, for whom a so-called ‘bias’ in the English-language media is a favourite theme, asking for an apology from the media comes very naturally. Yogendra looked shell-shocked, fearing his integrity was being questioned.

By afternoon, the final results were out—the Samajwadi Party had indeed swept the polls, the BJP had been routed, our numbers had been proven absolutely correct. I wish the same BJP leader had appeared on our prime-time evening bulletin that day. I might have been tempted to demand a similar apology from her for her all-too-ready suspicion of the media and its motives.

Traumatic or not, we were all rushing to kick off the exit poll race. Election Commission rules prohibited announcing any findings till the last vote had been cast. So at 5.30 p.m. on 12 May, once the final round of voting was done, every channel began blasting their poll results. Some screamed louder than others, but for once most of the polls were pointing in